

“I like reading books and stuff but not on something a white man wrote,” she said. “I’ve been doing it up until this grade, and I don’t want to continue to do it for another four years.” (I love Cristina.)

As Jasmine’s and Cristina’s experiences highlight, there is no shame in deciding you’d rather save the money, in moving forward in your future a different way, or in not being ready to go to college. I’ve never believed that you automatically become an adult the day you turn 18. As the wise Jasmine said, “I still have to ask to go to the bathroom, but I’m supposed to know what I want to do with the rest of my life as soon as I walk across the stage?”

Don’t keep the money aspect of college a secret, and don’t stress prestige over practicality. I was surprised to learn how many of the current high school and college students I talked to had had serious discussions with their parents about paying for school. It was so unlike my own experience. Many said their parents told them frankly that when it came to paying for college, they were on their own. There was no emotional boohooing about it.

The problem is twofold: Parents don’t talk to their kids about how they’re affording college as a family or about scholarships or about realistic expectations for where they can apply, and kids don’t talk to *each other* about what their other plans might be for after high school or if they’re attending, about how they’re really affording college.

FINANCIAL AID

There are steps we can take to prepare though. Kelly Peeler, founder of NextGenVest, a college financial prep company, told me the stunning news that it’s possible to negotiate your college tuition. When I was 18, I would have been terrified. Who wants to be the thorn in your new university’s side before you even get there?

Former dean of admissions at Columbia Anna Ivey agreed that the first financial aid package you receive is just a suggestion. It’s up to you to fill in any circumstances or changes in income that you think might lower the number. (On the flip side, if your parent landed a new job or you inherited family money,